

Death v2 — Iron Hands Pivot Assessment

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Evaluation of an **Iron Hands** pivot for the Death v2 project, built on Jared Garcia's "Baby Shark" list (6th at Northern Maelstrom 2026) and tested two ways: against the *real* opponents Garcia beat on the day, and — as an out-of-sample stress test — against the top of a completely different event (Denver 40K Fight Club Aug Open '26). Data from the committed field pulls ([data/bcp/nm2026*](#), [data/bcp/denver-aug2026*](#)); sim via the positional board-control runbook.

Headline

- **Baby Shark validates as the Death v2 chassis.** It went **5-1 in its own NM2026 meta** and, in a cross-event sim against a field it never saw, was **board-favoured in 8 of 9** Denver top finishers. The board-control identity is meta-portable, not matchup-fit to one event.
- **The engine is durability, not alpha.** The T6 Heavy Intercessors anchor the objective war in every game (82-97% survival); the list wins by out-lasting, not out-punching.
- **The ceiling is set by two identifiable shapes**, not by a faction: elite Dark Angels burst/secondary lists, and mass-OC durable gunlines. Both are prep-able.
- **Recommendation: pivot to Iron Hands.** This is a tougher, more forgiving board-control chassis than a Lancer-less Knights rebuild, and it does the thing the LSO data said Knights should do (durable board hold + concentrated guns) more naturally than Knights can.

1. The list — "Baby Shark" (Iron Hands, Librarius Conclave, 1990pts)

Unit	Pts	Role
Terminator Assault Squad (10, 2+/4++, thunder hammers)	360	Hammer / board anchor
Hellblaster Squad	220	Ranged workhorse
Heavy Intercessor Squad (T6)	200	Durable board anchor
Gladiator Lancer	160	Anti-tank
Assault Intercessor Squad	150	Board / trade
Ballistus Dreadnought	150	Anti-tank / fire support
Infiltrator Squad	110	Screen / deny deep strike

Librarian x2	85 / 95	Conclave enablers
Caanok Var	90	Character
Iron Father Feirros	85	Iron Hands buff character
Ancient in Terminator Armour	85	Terminator support
Apothecary Biologis	80	Buff / heal
Intercessor Squad	80	Board / OC
Apothecary	40	Heal

Loads into the sim with **zero unresolved datasheets** — fully modellable.

2. NM2026 — the actual gauntlet to 6th (5-1)

What Garcia beat on the day, with the sim's read of each matchup:

	Opponent (finish)	Actual	Sim verdict	Board margin
1	Rothman — Space Marines (#13)	W 90-75	HARD	−0.62
2	Ganshyn — Grey Knights (#93)	W 85-71	FAVOURED	+0.69
3	Pedretti — Death Guard (#86)	W 100-79	EVEN / GRINDY	+0.14
4	Cook — Space Wolves (#21)	W 73-43	FAVOURED	+1.04
5	McCord — Dark Angels (#2)	L 79-99	FAVOURED	+1.27
6	Howard — Chaos Knights (#16)	W 97-22	FAVOURED	+0.95

This is a genuine 5-1 — three top-25 opponents beaten, and the only loss to the eventual event runner-up. The board model rated the McCord game **favourable** (+1.27) yet Garcia lost 79-99: the loss came from what the positional sim does not capture — top-tier Dark Angels burst + secondary scoring, the same apex archetype flagged UNFAVOURABLE at LSO.

3. Denver cross-event stress test (out-of-sample)

Baby Shark run against the loadable Denver top finishers — a field it never faced, in a different meta (Orks/Daemons/Guard-heavy, no DA/Votann apex). 500 games/matchup.

Plc	Opponent	Faction	Sim verdict	Board margin
1	Mason Mutz	Orks (winner)	FAVOURED	+1.60

2	John Gianforte	Chaos Daemons	FAVOURED	+0.43
5	Steven Pampreen	Orks	FAVOURED	+0.85
6	Joel Davis	Orks	FAVOURED	+1.42
7	Calvin Fertig	Astra Militarum	FAVOURED	+0.44
8	Hunter Williams	Dark Angels	FAVOURED	+0.84
9	Lane Nusbaum	Astra Militarum	EVEN / GRINDY	−0.27
10	Khael Hopkins	Necrons	FAVOURED	+0.44
11	Colin Kay	SM — Librarius Conclave	FAVOURED	+0.90

Favoured 8 • Even 1 • Hard 0. The board margin is Garcia minus opponent (avg objectives/turn).

Three findings:

1. **The chassis travels.** Board-favoured in 8 of 9 against a meta it never saw. The durable T6 Heavy Intercessors are the MVP anchor in every matchup — they win the objective war regardless of opponent.
2. **Dark Angels is not automatically the wall.** Denver's #8 DA came back FAVOURED (+0.84), whereas NM2026's McCord DA **beat** Garcia. It is not "DA hard" — it is "elite DA burst/secondary lists" that exceed the board model. Ordinary DA, Baby Shark out-grinds.
3. **Beats a standard Marine mirror.** vs #11 Colin Kay's Librarius Conclave Marines (+0.90): the Terminators (49.6 wounds/turn) plus the T6 wall push Kay off the board entirely by R4. Against the "normal" Marine list, Baby Shark is simply more durable and more board-sticky.

4. The two threats — and how they differ

Across both events, the games that trouble Baby Shark cluster into **two shapes** that want opposite answers:

- **Elite burst + secondary game** (McCord DA, NM2026). The board reads favourable but they win on removal speed and secondary tempo. **Answer:** faster threat removal / secondary denial; do not trust the board lead alone.
- **Mass-OC durable gunline** (Nusbaum "Grizzled Company" Guard, Denver). They out-board Baby Shark early (objectives 1.5/2.1/1.6 vs 1.0/0.6/0.9 across R1-3) by flooding OC bodies, anchoring on a

Rogal Dorn Commander, and fielding Ogryns + a Hellhound the list **can't reliably remove**.

Answer: more early board presence and a plan for un-removable durable chaff.

5. Consistent liabilities (screen these every game)

The fragile enablers die for nothing if exposed and appear as liabilities across matchups:

**both Librarians, the Ancient in Terminator Armour, the Apothecary Biologis, and the Ballistus

Dreadnought.** Screen or hold them until they matter; the Conclave engine is also the soft spot.

6. Recommendation

Pivot to Iron Hands / Baby Shark as the Death v2 base. It is validated across two metas as a durable, meta-portable board-control list, and its identity aligns with the empirical LSO finding (durable board hold + concentrated guns beats the melee-investment Knights build). Its ceiling is set by two specific, identifiable archetypes — both of which we now know to prep for.

Next steps if adopted: (a) test a list tweak that shores up the mass-OC-gunline matchup without losing the durable core; (b) build a secondary-denial plan for elite DA; (c) re-run both gauntlets after any list change to confirm the board identity holds.